

A NOTE ABOUT VIRTUALISATION SOFTWARE

While it's safe to try any of the popular Linux distributions today on your machine, it's advisable that you install the OS on a virtual machine. Especially, if you have a dual-boot setup, create a virtual machine, simulate the installation and see if you understand the procedure. While virtualisation will help your mind be at ease and make sure that everything goes as smoothly as possible, it's crucial to have your important data backed up. When installing an OS, all kinds of things can go wrong – from power failures and unexpected hangs, to boot-loader installation failures and partitioning and resizing processes going wrong. Hence, please back up your data.

Also, if during the distro's installation process, any kind of media test is offered, do run it. Again, it wouldn't hurt to have a power backup system (UPS) just in case electricity goes off. For laptop owners, this would mean ensuring that your machine's battery is in healthy condition and well charged.



As far as networking is concerned, India has caught up to speed and its internet services are now more reliable than ever before. While most of semi-urban India still surfs the net on half a megabit per second, it's not uncommon to see multi-megabits per second (usually 2 or 4 Mbps) connections. This supports Linux installations since the installer will be able to quickly download system updates.

Effects of desktop computing

Users have come to understand that a machine's usability trumps fancy effects. An OS with great effects that crashes when you launch the browser wouldn't see the light of anyone's living room, while one with decent enough animations and great usability and robustness will prosper and serve its users for years. Linux, in this aspect, has made tremendous strides. The apps that would once fight each other for supremacy are now all being integrated into decent and stable UIs to provide a coherent experience. This means that many of Mac OS X's innovations are featuring alongside Microsoft's and the OSS community is only too pleased with the experience.